

PreACT 8/9 Printable Practice Exam 11

Reading • Exam 03

25 questions • 30 minutes

PART A - QUESTIONS

Passage 1

The Rain Practice

Jonas had written every sentence he planned to say during the school's outdoor jazz festival. His script included the names of twelve performers, the titles of nine songs, and one joke about the cafeteria's mysterious soup. He had even marked where to breathe. From a small table beside the courtyard stage, he would introduce each act for listeners following the festival on the school's online radio station.

"You know you're allowed to look up," said Priya, who was managing the stage.

Jonas tapped the pages into a perfect stack. "Looking up is how people lose their place."

An hour before the broadcast, rain struck the courtyard in heavy, slanting lines. Music stands vanished under plastic covers, and the performers carried their instruments into the gym. The festival could continue there, but every drumbeat bounced from the high walls. When Jonas tested his microphone at a table near the bleachers, his own voice returned to him a moment later as a muddy echo.

Mr. Vale, the custodian, led Jonas and Priya to a storage balcony above the gym. Thick curtains and boxes of uniforms absorbed much of the sound. From there, the broadcast was clear—but a stack of folded mats blocked Jonas's view of the stage.

"I can signal when each group is ready," Priya offered. She demonstrated: one hand raised for wait, two fingers pointed forward for begin, and a small circle in the air if Jonas needed to keep talking.

Jonas imagined his careful script depending on signals he had never practiced. "What if I don't see you?"

"Then listen," Priya said. "You can hear the applause from up here."

The opening went smoothly. Before the fourth act, however, a trumpet valve stuck. Priya drew a circle in the air. Jonas's script contained only the group's name and song title, enough for fifteen seconds. The delay stretched beyond a minute.

Jonas looked through the balcony rail. He could not see the stage, but he heard a few musicians quietly repeating a difficult rhythm below. He remembered interviewing them earlier that week. Setting aside his script, he explained how the group had practiced that rhythm by tapping it on cafeteria tables. As he spoke, the nervous silence in his headphones seemed to settle. Priya finally pointed two fingers forward.

Later, the rain softened, but the festival remained in the gym. Jonas began noticing details his pages did not contain: the scrape of chairs before a large ensemble, the quick hush that meant a solo was about to begin, the different shapes of applause after a lively song and a quiet one. His script still anchored the broadcast, but it no longer fenced him in.

After the final song, Priya climbed to the balcony. "You skipped the soup joke," she said.

Jonas glanced at the untouched line. "The audience survived."

He folded the script instead of tapping it into a stack. On the last page, beneath his planned closing, he wrote a new reminder for the next broadcast: Leave room for what happens.

R3-001

Why do Jonas and Priya move the broadcast equipment to the storage balcony?

- A) The performers need Jonas's table for their instruments.
- B) Priya wants to prevent Jonas from watching the performance.
- C) The curtains and stored items reduce the gym's echo, making the broadcast clearer.
- D) The courtyard signal cannot reach the online radio station.

R3-002

It can reasonably be inferred that Jonas is initially uneasy about Priya's signal system because he:

- A) prefers relying on a plan he can control rather than on unfamiliar cues.
- B) believes Priya does not know the names of the performers.
- C) expects the outdoor festival to resume before the broadcast begins.
- D) cannot understand the meaning of any hand gesture.

R3-003

In the sentence "His script still anchored the broadcast, but it no longer fenced him in," the word "anchored" most nearly means:

- A) made impossible to hear.
- B) caused to end early.
- C) prevented from changing locations.
- D) provided a steady foundation for.

R3-004

What is the main function of the trumpet delay in the passage?

- A) It proves that the performers did not practice their music.
- B) It forces Jonas beyond his prepared material and gives him a chance to respond using what he hears and remembers.
- C) It explains why the festival returns to the courtyard.
- D) It shows that Priya's hand signals are too complicated to use.

R3-005

How does Jonas's approach to broadcasting change during the festival?

- A) He stops introducing performers and lets Priya speak for the rest of the event.
- B) He abandons all preparation and decides scripts are never useful.
- C) He continues using his script but becomes willing to listen, improvise, and leave room for unplanned events.
- D) He moves back to the echoing table so he can see every performer.

R3-006

Which choice best summarizes the passage?

- A) When rain forces a festival broadcast into an unfamiliar setup, Jonas learns to combine careful preparation with attention and improvisation.
- B) Jonas refuses to broadcast from the gym because Priya changes his planned closing joke.
- C) A broken microphone causes Jonas to replace the jazz festival with recorded interviews.
- D) Priya writes a new script after Jonas forgets the performers' names and song titles.

Passage 2

Passage A: Bring Back the Lettering

Above a corner grocery in my town, a faded wall advertisement shows the remains of enormous gold letters. Most pedestrians cannot read the store name that once stretched across the bricks. As a sign

painter, I support repainting signs like this one when reliable photographs and paint samples reveal the original design.

Repainting can recover more than bright color. Traditional signs were planned around the shape of a building and painted by hand with long, controlled strokes. A careful restoration gives present-day painters a chance to study and practice those methods. Community workshops can invite residents to trace letter forms, mix sample colors, and learn why the sign was placed where it was. The wall becomes evidence of past craft and a place where the craft continues.

Restoration must not become invention. Missing words should not be guessed, and new paint should be documented so future viewers know which layer is modern. When enough evidence survives, however, leaving a sign unreadable is not the only respectful choice. Repainting can return a piece of public design to the conversation of the street.

Passage B: Let the Fading Remain Visible

Old wall signs are sometimes called “ghost signs” because their letters appear and disappear with the light. Their value lies partly in this worn surface. Fading, chipped paint, and overlapping words can show that a building changed owners or that one advertisement was painted over another. A newly bright version may reproduce the first design while covering evidence of everything that happened later.

Preservation does not require abandoning a sign. Specialists can stabilize loose paint and repair the wall so that surviving layers do not vanish unnecessarily. They can also place a panel nearby showing a color reconstruction based on photographs. Visitors then see both an interpretation of the sign’s earlier appearance and the actual surface that has traveled through time.

Some signs are too damaged to interpret, and others may be repainted for strong community reasons. Yet restoration should begin with a question: What information would new paint conceal? An old sign is not merely an image printed on bricks. It is a stack of events, and wear can be one of the records in that stack.

R3-007

Which choice best states the central idea of Passage A?

- A) Every faded sign should be covered with a completely new advertisement.
- B) Historic signs matter only when their original stores are still open.
- C) Modern sign painters should avoid studying older painting methods.
- D) Evidence-based repainting can restore a sign’s public presence and help continue traditional craft.

R3-008

Which description best characterizes the author’s perspective in Passage A?

- A) The author believes historical evidence limits creativity and should be ignored.
- B) The author favors careful restoration but warns against inventing details that evidence does not support.
- C) The author is undecided about whether hand-painted signs have any public value.
- D) The author prefers that faded signs be moved indoors and hidden from the street.

R3-009

According to Passage B, what might be lost when an old sign is repainted?

- A) Evidence of later changes, such as overlapping signs, fading, and wear.
- B) The ability to show a reconstructed image on a nearby panel.
- C) All knowledge of the sign’s earliest colors and wording.
- D) The building’s ability to support loose paint safely.

R3-010

As used in Passage B, “stabilize” most nearly means:

- A) replace with an unrelated design.

- B) make brighter than the original.
- C) secure against further unnecessary loss.
- D) move from an outdoor wall into a museum.

R3-011

The passages differ mainly in that Passage A emphasizes:

- A) the financial value of old advertisements, while Passage B emphasizes their legal ownership.
- B) how weather makes signs easier to read, while Passage B explains how buildings are constructed.
- C) why all damaged signs should be removed, while Passage B argues they should be sold.
- D) recovering a supported earlier design, while Passage B emphasizes preserving the evidence of change and wear.

R3-012

Which statement would both authors most likely support?

- A) Restorers should invent missing words whenever a sign is difficult to read.
- B) Decisions about an old sign should be based on evidence and should clearly distinguish interpretation from surviving material.
- C) The only respectful treatment is to leave every wall completely untouched.
- D) Modern viewers should be prevented from learning how a sign once appeared.

Passage 3

A Question Before the Facts

Museum labels often begin by naming an object and explaining what it does. Researcher Amara Bell wondered whether beginning with a question instead might change how visitors examine an exhibit. Her team tested two kinds of labels at a science museum’s display of gears, mirrors, fossils, and other objects.

For each of twelve exhibit stations, the team wrote two labels containing the same central facts and nearly the same number of words. A fact-first label at a gear display began by explaining how a small gear turns a larger one. The question-first version asked visitors to predict which gear would complete more turns before presenting the same explanation. Every two days, the researchers switched which version appeared at each station. This rotation reduced the chance that one label type would always be paired with a more crowded day or a more popular object.

With visitors’ permission, observers recorded how long family groups stayed at a station and noted comments about predicting, testing, or revising an idea. Before leaving the museum, willing visitors answered four factual questions and one new application question. The application question required them to use an idea from an exhibit in a different situation.

Groups spent an average of thirty-eight seconds at question-first labels and twenty-four seconds at fact-first labels. At question-first stations, observers also recorded more comments such as “Let’s test it” and “I thought the other one would move faster.” Scores on the four factual questions were similar for both groups. On the application question, however, visitors who had encountered mostly question-first labels were somewhat more successful.

In interviews, several adults said the opening questions gave children something specific to watch for. One child explained, “I had to choose before I knew, so I wanted to find out if my guess could survive.” Some visitors offered a different response: they skipped questions when tired or when the exhibit area felt crowded.

The researchers cautioned that longer viewing is not automatically better learning. A confusing label could also hold attention. In this study, though, the conversation notes and application responses support the idea that many visitors were doing more than simply standing still. The team also noted that museum visitors had chosen to come to a science museum, so the results may not describe people with little interest in the topic.

Bell's study suggests that a small change in order can alter the role of a label. Instead of immediately supplying an answer, a label can first give visitors a reason to examine the evidence in front of them.

R3-013

Which choice best states the main idea of the passage?

- A) Museum visitors remember facts only when labels contain very few words.
- B) Science museums should remove labels and let visitors interpret every object alone.
- C) Opening labels with questions may encourage visitors to examine, discuss, and apply exhibit ideas more actively.
- D) Family groups avoid museum exhibits that contain gears, mirrors, or fossils.

R3-014

Which result did the researchers observe?

- A) Visitors at question-first labels spent more time on average and made more comments about testing or revising ideas.
- B) Visitors at fact-first labels answered every factual question correctly.
- C) Question-first labels caused all tired visitors to remain at every exhibit.
- D) Fact-first visitors were much more successful on the new application question.

R3-015

What is the main purpose of including the child's statement that the guess had to "survive"?

- A) To show that the child thought the exhibit was physically dangerous.
- B) To prove that every visitor understood every question-first label.
- C) To explain why observers stopped recording visitor conversations.
- D) To illustrate how making a prediction gave one visitor a reason to check it against the exhibit.

R3-016

Why did each pair of labels contain the same central facts and nearly the same number of words?

- A) To make all visitors spend exactly the same amount of time reading.
- B) To make the order and presence of the opening question the main planned difference between versions.
- C) To prevent the researchers from switching labels among exhibit stations.
- D) To ensure that every application response would be correct.

R3-017

Which combination of findings most strongly supports the interpretation that question-first visitors were actively reasoning rather than simply remaining at exhibits longer?

- A) The museum displayed twelve objects, and labels were switched every two days.
- B) Some visitors skipped questions when tired, and all participants had chosen to visit the museum.
- C) Observers heard more prediction and revision comments, and question-first visitors did somewhat better on a new application problem.
- D) Question-first labels had nearly the same number of words as fact-first labels, and factual scores were similar.

R3-018

Which choice best describes the passage's overall structure?

- A) It introduces a research question, describes a controlled label comparison, reports multiple kinds of evidence, and then discusses limits and implications.
- B) It ranks museum objects by popularity and recommends removing the least popular exhibits.
- C) It presents two researchers' biographies before describing the history of science museums.
- D) It begins with a proven conclusion and then argues that visitor observations are unnecessary.

Passage 4

Paths Already in the Soil

A growing root tip pushes between grains of soil, but not every route offers equal resistance. Old worm tunnels, gaps left by decayed roots, and cracks formed during dry weather can remain below the surface. Plant scientist Dev Suri wanted to know whether roots use such open channels simply because the channels are easy to enter or because water and nutrients also guide them.

Suri's team filled sixty transparent columns with the same packed soil and planted one bean seedling in each. In some columns, the researchers formed a narrow open channel that passed near the seedling and continued downward. Half of these open channels received plain water, while the other half received a weak nutrient solution. A third set of columns received the same nutrient solution, but their channels were refilled with packed soil. The remaining columns had no prepared channel and received plain water spread across the surface.

The team photographed each column before planting and then every six hours for twelve days. Fine marks on the transparent sides allowed the researchers to measure when a root changed direction, entered a prepared channel, and extended downward.

Roots entered 66 percent of the open channels supplied with plain water. They entered 82 percent of the open channels supplied with nutrients. By comparison, roots followed only 45 percent of the nutrient-treated channels that had been filled again with soil. Once inside an open channel, roots generally extended downward faster than roots pushing through packed soil.

The results suggest that both structure and resources matter. The high use of plain-water channels shows that a low-resistance path can attract roots even without added nutrients. The additional use of nutrient-supplied open channels suggests that chemical conditions can strengthen that effect. Meanwhile, the lower use of filled nutrient channels shows that nutrients alone did not completely overcome the resistance of packed soil.

The photographs revealed another detail. Some roots began curving toward nutrient-treated channels shortly before touching them, while roots approaching plain-water channels usually changed direction only after reaching an opening. Dissolved substances may have moved a short distance through the damp soil, providing information before contact. The experiment did not identify which substance produced the response.

Suri described open channels as conduits rather than guaranteed routes. A root might enter one, leave it, or miss it entirely. In natural soil, channels also differ in width, moisture, and age, and they may contain other roots or animals. Because the columns simplified these conditions, field studies are needed before the results can be applied broadly. Even so, the study shows that roots respond to the physical history of soil as well as to the materials currently dissolved within it.

R3-019

Which choice best states the central idea of the passage?

- A) Roots enter underground channels only when the channels contain concentrated nutrients.
- B) Packed soil allows roots to grow downward faster than any open space does.
- C) Bean roots cannot change direction until they touch the wall of a transparent container.
- D) Roots respond to both low-resistance soil pathways and resource conditions, though neither guarantees a particular route.

R3-020

Why did the researchers include nutrient-treated channels that were refilled with packed soil?

- A) To prevent every root from receiving any water during the study.
- B) To examine the influence of nutrients when the low-resistance open pathway was removed.
- C) To provide the only columns in which researchers could photograph roots.
- D) To imitate channels occupied by soil animals in the field.

R3-021

As used in the final paragraph, “conduits” most nearly means:

- A) barriers that roots cannot cross.
- B) chemicals produced by root tips.
- C) pathways through which something may travel.
- D) measurements taken from photographs.

R3-022

Which step occurred before the researchers began photographing the columns every six hours?

- A) They prepared the channel conditions and photographed the columns before planting.
- B) They identified the exact dissolved substance that caused roots to curve.
- C) They moved all seedlings from the columns into natural field soil.
- D) They concluded that roots followed every open channel.

R3-023

What can reasonably be inferred from roots curving toward nutrient-treated channels before touching them?

- A) The roots could see the transparent marks on the columns.
- B) Open channels prevented dissolved substances from moving through damp soil.
- C) The roots always followed nutrient channels from the moment they sprouted.
- D) A dissolved cue may have reached nearby roots through the soil before physical contact with the channel.

R3-024

What is the main function of the final paragraph?

- A) To claim that the simplified columns exactly reproduce every natural soil condition.
- B) To limit the scope of the results while explaining their broader significance for understanding root growth.
- C) To introduce a second experiment that reverses all the reported findings.
- D) To argue that field studies should replace all laboratory research.

R3-025

Which choice best summarizes the study’s findings?

- A) Nutrients caused every root to enter a channel, even when the channel was packed with soil.
- B) Plain-water channels had no effect because roots respond only to dissolved chemicals.
- C) Roots often used open channels, especially nutrient-supplied ones, while packed soil reduced channel use and nearby nutrients may have guided some roots before contact.
- D) Roots grew at identical speeds and followed identical paths in all four conditions.

PART B - ANSWER KEY + EXPLANATIONS

R3-001 - Correct: C) The curtains and stored items reduce the gym's echo, making the broadcast clearer.

Explanation: Near the bleachers, Jonas's voice returns as a muddy echo. The balcony's curtains and boxes absorb much of the sound, allowing a clear broadcast.

R3-002 - Correct: A) prefers relying on a plan he can control rather than on unfamiliar cues.

Explanation: Jonas has scripted every sentence and even marked his breathing. He worries when his prepared broadcast must depend on signals he has never practiced.

R3-003 - Correct: D) provided a steady foundation for.

Explanation: Jonas continues using the script for support while adding unscripted observations, so it provides a stable foundation without limiting everything he says.

R3-004 - Correct: B) It forces Jonas beyond his prepared material and gives him a chance to respond using what he hears and remembers.

Explanation: The delay lasts longer than Jonas's scripted material. He must set the script aside and use the musicians' sounds and a previous interview to keep speaking.

R3-005 - Correct: C) He continues using his script but becomes willing to listen, improvise, and leave room for unplanned events.

Explanation: The script remains an anchor, but Jonas adds details from sounds and experience. His final note explicitly reminds him to leave room for what happens.

R3-006 - Correct: A) When rain forces a festival broadcast into an unfamiliar setup, Jonas learns to combine careful preparation with attention and improvisation.

Explanation: The indoor move and blocked view disrupt Jonas's exact plan, but he successfully adapts by using signals, sounds, memories, and his script together.

R3-007 - Correct: D) Evidence-based repainting can restore a sign's public presence and help continue traditional craft.

Explanation: Passage A supports repainting when photographs and samples provide reliable evidence, arguing that the process makes signs legible and allows the craft to be studied and practiced.

R3-008 - Correct: B) The author favors careful restoration but warns against inventing details that evidence does not support.

Explanation: The author supports repainting supported by photographs and samples, while clearly stating that missing words should not be guessed and modern work should be documented.

R3-009 - Correct: A) Evidence of later changes, such as overlapping signs, fading, and wear.

Explanation: Passage B explains that fading, chips, and overlapping words can record later events, and that new paint may cover this evidence.

R3-010 - Correct: C) secure against further unnecessary loss.

Explanation: Specialists stabilize loose paint and repair the wall so surviving layers do not vanish unnecessarily, meaning they secure what remains.

R3-011 - Correct: D) recovering a supported earlier design, while Passage B emphasizes preserving the evidence of change and wear.

Explanation: Passage A presents accurate repainting as a way to restore legibility and craft. Passage B warns that repainting can conceal the later history visible in worn and overlapping layers.

R3-012 - Correct: B) Decisions about an old sign should be based on evidence and should clearly distinguish interpretation from surviving material.

Explanation: Passage A requires reliable evidence and documentation of new paint. Passage B supports preserving the original surface while labeling a separate reconstruction based on photographs.

R3-013 - Correct: C) Opening labels with questions may encourage visitors to examine, discuss, and apply exhibit ideas more actively.

Explanation: Question-first labels were associated with longer visits, more prediction and revision comments, and somewhat better performance on a new application question.

R3-014 - Correct: A) Visitors at question-first labels spent more time on average and made more comments about testing or revising ideas.

Explanation: Groups averaged thirty-eight seconds at question-first labels compared with twenty-four seconds at fact-first labels, and observers recorded more testing and revision comments.

R3-015 - Correct: D) To illustrate how making a prediction gave one visitor a reason to check it against the exhibit.

Explanation: The child says choosing an answer first created a desire to find out whether the guess held up, illustrating the active examination the researchers were studying.

R3-016 - Correct: B) To make the order and presence of the opening question the main planned difference between versions.

Explanation: Keeping content and length similar reduces alternative explanations, allowing the researchers to focus on the effect of presenting a question before the facts.

R3-017 - Correct: C) Observers heard more prediction and revision comments, and question-first visitors did somewhat better on a new application problem.

Explanation: Prediction and revision comments directly show visitors testing ideas, while success on a new application question indicates use of the concept beyond simple viewing time.

R3-018 - Correct: A) It introduces a research question, describes a controlled label comparison, reports multiple kinds of evidence, and then discusses limits and implications.

Explanation: The passage moves from Bell's question to the two label versions, explains observations and assessments, and closes with cautions and a broader interpretation.

R3-019 - Correct: D) Roots respond to both low-resistance soil pathways and resource conditions, though neither guarantees a particular route.

Explanation: Roots frequently used plain-water open channels, used nutrient open channels even more, and used filled nutrient channels less often, showing effects from both structure and resources.

R3-020 - Correct: B) To examine the influence of nutrients when the low-resistance open pathway was removed.

Explanation: These columns contained the nutrient treatment but not an open route. Comparing them with open nutrient channels helped separate the influence of resources from reduced soil resistance.

R3-021 - Correct: C) pathways through which something may travel.

Explanation: Suri contrasts conduits with guaranteed routes and notes that roots can enter, leave, or miss them, so the word refers to possible pathways.

R3-022 - Correct: A) They prepared the channel conditions and photographed the columns before planting.

Explanation: The team created the different channel treatments and photographed each column before planting, then took photographs every six hours for twelve days.

R3-023 - Correct: D) A dissolved cue may have reached nearby roots through the soil before physical contact with the channel.

Explanation: The passage proposes that dissolved substances moved a short distance through damp soil, providing information to approaching roots before they reached the channel.

R3-024 - Correct: B) To limit the scope of the results while explaining their broader significance for understanding root growth.

Explanation: The paragraph explains that natural channels are more complex and calls for field studies, while retaining the broader conclusion that roots respond to soil history and dissolved materials.

R3-025 - Correct: C) Roots often used open channels, especially nutrient-supplied ones, while packed soil reduced channel use and nearby nutrients may have guided some roots before contact.

Explanation: Open channels were used more than filled channels, nutrient open channels had the highest use, and some roots curved toward nutrient treatments before reaching them.